Daily Maverick Story Package Pitch

Daily Maverick — Story Package Pitch

Commission Research Intelligence Dashboard | Data-Driven Commission Coverage

---

1. The Product: What We're Selling

A **weekly story package** delivered every Monday. Each package gives a journalist everything they need to produce a data-backed commission story in hours, not days.

Weekly Deliverables

Deliverable	Format	Length	Description
YouTube-style script	Written doc	8–12 pages	Deep-dive narrative script with data visualizations, entity connections, and transcript references
Podcast script	Written doc	4–6 pages	Conversational audio script (15–25 min episode) ready for recording
TikTok / Short script	Written doc	1 page	Hook-driven 60–90 sec viral script for social distribution
Visual story map	Image file	1-page infographic	Entity-connection map or timeline highlighting the week's key finding

What Makes It Unique

- **Every claim is sourced** — each script references specific hearing days, page numbers, and speaker names from the commission record
- **Entity cross-referencing** — surfaces connections across 147+ hearing days that no human journalist can manually find
- **Network data** — visual maps of who said what about whom
- **Speed** — delivered Monday morning, before any other outlet has cross-referenced the previous week's testimony

---

2. Target Journalists & Editors

Name	Role	Why Them	Contact
Caryn Dolley	Investigations Reporter, Daily Maverick	Covered Madlanga Commission extensively; wrote on Big Five cartel, in-camera hearings	Via Daily Maverick website or X/Twitter
Marianne Thamm	Assistant Editor, Daily Maverick	Senior editorial oversight; can greenlight partnerships	Via Daily Maverick editorial
Rebecca Davis	Senior Reporter, Daily Maverick	Daily commission coverage; sued over in-camera hearings	Via Daily Maverick or X/Twitter
Styli Charalambous	Head of Video, Daily Maverick	Controls video/documentary production; YouTube and social video	Via Daily Maverick

---

3. Email Pitch Template

Subject Line Options

- *"Data intelligence for your Madlanga coverage — free 2-week trial"*
- *"Every connection your commission reporters might be missing"*
- *"147 days of testimony, cross-referenced — yours weekly"*

Body

> *Hi [Name],*
> *I've been following your Madlanga Commission coverage — particularly your work on [specific story they wrote].*
> *I've built something that might interest you: a **Commission Research Intelligence Dashboard** that ingests, cross-references, and visualizes every piece of testimony across all 147+ hearing days.*
> *It finds connections no human journalist can manually catch — like which witnesses across months of testimony named the same entity, or when a witness last week contradicted a witness from three months ago.*
> ***I'd like to offer you a free 2-week trial.***
> *Every Monday for two weeks, I'll send you: - A **YouTube-style deep-dive script** with sourced data and visual story maps - A **podcast script** ready for recording - A **TikTok/Short script** for social distribution - A **visual entity map** showing the week's key connections*
> *No cost. No commitment. Just a demonstration of what data-driven commission coverage looks like.*
> *After the trial, if you see value, we can talk about a weekly or monthly package.*
> *Keen to show you what it can do.*
> *[Name]*

---

4. Pricing Tiers

Tier 1: Weekly Package

Item	Detail
Price	**R7,000/week**
Deliverables	Full script suite every Monday (YouTube + podcast + TikTok + visual map)
Best for	Trial period, or outlets wanting flexibility

Tier 2: Monthly Package

Item	Detail
Price	**R25,000/month**
Deliverables	4 weeks of script suites + 1 bonus deep-dive
Saving vs weekly	R3,000/month (save 1 week)
Best for	Outlets committed to sustained commission coverage

Tier 3: Quarterly Package

Item	Detail
Price	**R60,000/quarter**
Deliverables	12 weeks of script suites + priority data access + custom research requests
Saving vs weekly	R24,000/quarter (save 3.5 weeks)
Best for	Deep partnerships; includes right to request specific entity/topic investigations

Value Comparison

Role	Monthly Cost	Our Monthly Package
One junior journalist	~R25,000–R35,000	**R25,000**
One senior journalist	~R45,000–R70,000	**R25,000**
Our package (vs hiring)	—	**60–80% less** than a junior researcher who would take 10x longer

---

5. Long-Game Expansion Plan

Phase 1: Hook Daily Maverick (Weeks 1–2)

- Free 2-week trial to Caryn Dolley, Marianne Thamm, Rebecca Davis, Styli Charalambous
- Deliver high-quality scripts that produce published stories
- Goal: They see the value and want more

Phase 2: Weekly → Monthly Retainer (Month 2+)

- Convert trial to paid weekly package
- Prove consistency over 4–8 weeks
- Upgrade to monthly retainer

Phase 3: Reference to News24 (Month 3)

- Use Daily Maverick as a testimonial reference
- Pitch News24's investigations desk
- News24 has a larger audience and deeper pockets
- Offer same free trial model (with DM as proof)

Phase 4: Deep-Dive Partner: amaBhungane (Month 4+)

- amaBhungane does long-form, high-impact investigative journalism
- They are slower (months per investigation) but produce award-winning work
- Pitch: *"I can give you every entity connection across 147 days for any topic you choose — in hours, not weeks"*
- One-off project pricing: R30,000–R80,000 per investigation

Phase 5: Sell to the Madlanga Commission Itself (Parallel Track)

- After building credibility through media partnerships
- Pitch the dashboard directly to the commission as a legal team research tool
- Price: R50,000+ (one-time deployment + training)
- Angle: *"The media is using this to cover you. Your own team should be using it too."*

Phase 6: Government Contract / Permanent Role (Endgame)

- Use commission deployment as a reference
- Pitch to Department of Justice for future commissions
- Pitch to SIU, NPA, or other investigative bodies
- Monthly retainer: R40,000–R80,000/month

---

6. Weekly Story Angle Ideas

Week 1: "The IDAC Connection"

- How IDAC's Andrea Johnson testimony (Days 144–146) connects to the Khumalo arrest
- Entity map: Johnson → Khumalo → Mokwele → Feroz Khan → whistleblower
- Script hook: *"The head of South Africa's elite anti-corruption unit spent 3 days denying she did anything wrong. The data tells a different story."*

Week 2: "The Missing Witnesses"

- Witnesses who were scheduled but never appeared
- Witnesses who testified in secret (in camera)
- Entity map: All named entities that were never fully examined
- Script hook: *"147 days of testimony. Hundreds of witnesses. But the most important voices may be the ones we never heard."*

Week 3: "The Cartel Map Update"

- Track how the "Big Five" cartel connections have evolved through testimony
- New entities and witnesses that emerged in recent weeks
- Updated network graph showing new connections
- Script hook: *"The Big Five cartel was named in September 2025. Here's everything we've learned since."*

---

7. Contact Strategy Summary

Target	Phase	Offer	Channel
Caryn Dolley	Phase 1	Free 2-week trial	Email / X
Marianne Thamm	Phase 1	Free 2-week trial	Email / X
Rebecca Davis	Phase 1	Free 2-week trial	Email / X
Styli Charalambous	Phase 1	Free 2-week trial (video focus)	Email / X
News24 investigations	Phase 3	Paid package + DM reference	Email
amaBhungane	Phase 4	One-off project pricing	Email
Madlanga Commission	Phase 5	R50k+ deployment	Email / formal proposal

---

8. Pricing Summary Table

Package	Price	Per-Week Rate	Saving vs Weekly	Best For
Weekly	R7,000	R7,000	—	Trial / flexibility
Monthly	R25,000	R6,250	R3,000/month	Sustained coverage
Quarterly	R60,000	R5,000	R24,000/quarter	Deep partnership
Commission deploy	R50,000+	One-time	—	Direct sale
Government contract	R40k–R80k/month	Retainer	—	Endgame

---

9. How the Dashboard Works as an Investigative Research Tool

Beyond delivering story packages, the dashboard itself functions as a **full investigative research platform** for journalists. Here is how a beat reporter or investigations journalist uses it to find stories that would otherwise require weeks of transcript-reading:

Entity Tracing — Following a Lead Across 147 Days

A journalist hears “Medicare 24” mentioned in a hearing. Instead of manually searching individual PDF transcripts, they type the name into the Entity Browser. The dashboard returns **every mention across all 147 hearing days** — who said it, when, and the exact context. The journalist sees patterns no single day of testimony reveals: Medicare 24 was named by Witness A in October, Witness B in January, and Witness C in April. None of these witnesses appeared on the same day, but the dashboard connects them through the entity they all named.

Story lead: A single entity connected across months of testimony by different witnesses — none of whom knew what the others said. The dashboard surfaces the connection; the journalist writes the story.

Network Graph — Visual Investigation

The interactive network graph maps every witness against every entity they named. Bigger nodes = more mentions. Closer nodes = more connections. A journalist exploring the graph sees:

- Which witnesses named the most entities (potential key sources)
- Which entities appear across the widest range of testimony (potential systemic issues)
- Which witnesses are isolated from the main network (potential outliers with unique information)

Story lead: A witness who named entities no one else mentioned — they have information no other witness corroborated. That is either a unique lead or a potential contradiction worth investigating.

Contradiction Detection — Sourced Investigative Angles

When two witnesses give conflicting accounts of the same entity, the dashboard flags it — with Day:Line citations for both versions. The journalist does not need a whistleblower or a leaked document. The contradiction is in the public record; the dashboard just makes it findable.

Story lead: *"Witness A told the commission X in March. Witness B told the commission Y in June. The commission's documents say Z. Who is telling the truth?"* Every claim sourced, every citation verifiable.

Speed — From Question to Story

Research Task	Manual Time	With Dashboard
Find every mention of an entity across 147 days	4–8 hours of PDF searching	10 seconds
Cross-reference a witness's testimony against documents	3–6 hours	2 minutes
Find potential contradictions between witnesses	2–4 hours per pair	Instant
Map the network of who said what about whom	8–16 hours one-off	Built automatically
Compile a sourced brief on a topic	4–8 hours	5 minutes

The journalist who covers the commission with the dashboard does not just work faster — they **find stories that would otherwise remain hidden** in the 23.8 million characters of transcript text that no single person can read and remember.

Internal pitch document. Pricing is negotiated per outlet; these are guideline figures based on the data intelligence value provided.